

Can potential trump pedigree?

The **Duleep Trophy** once sat at the heart of India's red-ball cricket landscape. Today, it is competing with a far more complex selection ecosystem.

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The biggest talking point ahead of this year's Duleep Trophy isn't a batter who scored close to 950 runs in the Ranji Trophy or a fast bowler who picked 60 wickets over the last two domestic seasons.

It's, instead, a 15-year-old vice-captain.

The East Zone selectors' decision to appoint Vaibhav Sooryavanshi as deputy to Ishan Kishan has dominated the build-up to the tournament.

Not because the teenager isn't good enough. In fact, few youngsters have captured the imagination quite like the Bihar batter has over the last year. If the selectors see him as a long-term India player, there is every reason to expose him to bigger stages early.

But even then, it has revived an old debate.

For decades, the Duleep Trophy represented the highest reward for sustained excellence in domestic cricket.

Leadership roles, too, generally went to players who had spent years proving themselves in the Ranji Trophy.

Sooryavanshi's elevation doesn't diminish his credentials, but it does reflect how the conversation around selection has evolved.

There is plenty to look forward to on the field as well.

Rajat Patidar leads Central Zone after another productive domestic season. Ruturaj Gaikwad captains a formidable West Zone side. Ishan returns to red-ball cricket as East Zone skipper, while Karun Nair, fresh from a prolific domestic campaign and back in the national reckoning, headlines South Zone. Mayank Agarwal, Sai Kishore, Prithvi Shaw, Harsh Dubey and Yash Dayal are among several players with plenty to play for.

The tournament also comes at an important time for the selectors.

India has a packed Test calendar ahead, and several places below the established core remain open. Fringe internationals, India A regulars and domestic performers all have another opportunity to strengthen their case.

There are openings at No. 3, in the middle order and even for a fast-bowling back-up. Rajat Patidar, Karun Nair and Ruturaj Gaikwad are

